SeeWandel Climate

Interreg
Alpenrhein-Bodensee-Hochrhein

Kofinanziert von der Europäischen Union

Regime Shifts in Plankton Dynamics: What Drives Them and Can We Predict Them?

Dr. Leonardo Capitani
Department of Aquatic Ecology, Eawag · SeeWandel-Climate

www.seewandel.org

Ecomeets @ Eawag, Dübendorf
28 October 2026

Open science: take the slides with you

Scan to download the slides

SORTEE
Society for Open, Reliable, and Transparent Ecology and Evolutionary Biology

Slides, code and data shared openly
leomarameo7.github.io/science_communication.html

Acknowledgements



Pomati lab
Plankton Ecology, Eawag



Steve Munch & Tanya Rogers
EDM workshop guests

SeeWandel Climate

SeeWandel-Climate

Interreg
Alpenrhein-Bodensee-Hochrhein

Kofinanziert von der Europäischen Union

Supported by the
Biodiversity Center WSL–Eawag

eawag aquatic research

WSL

Take home message

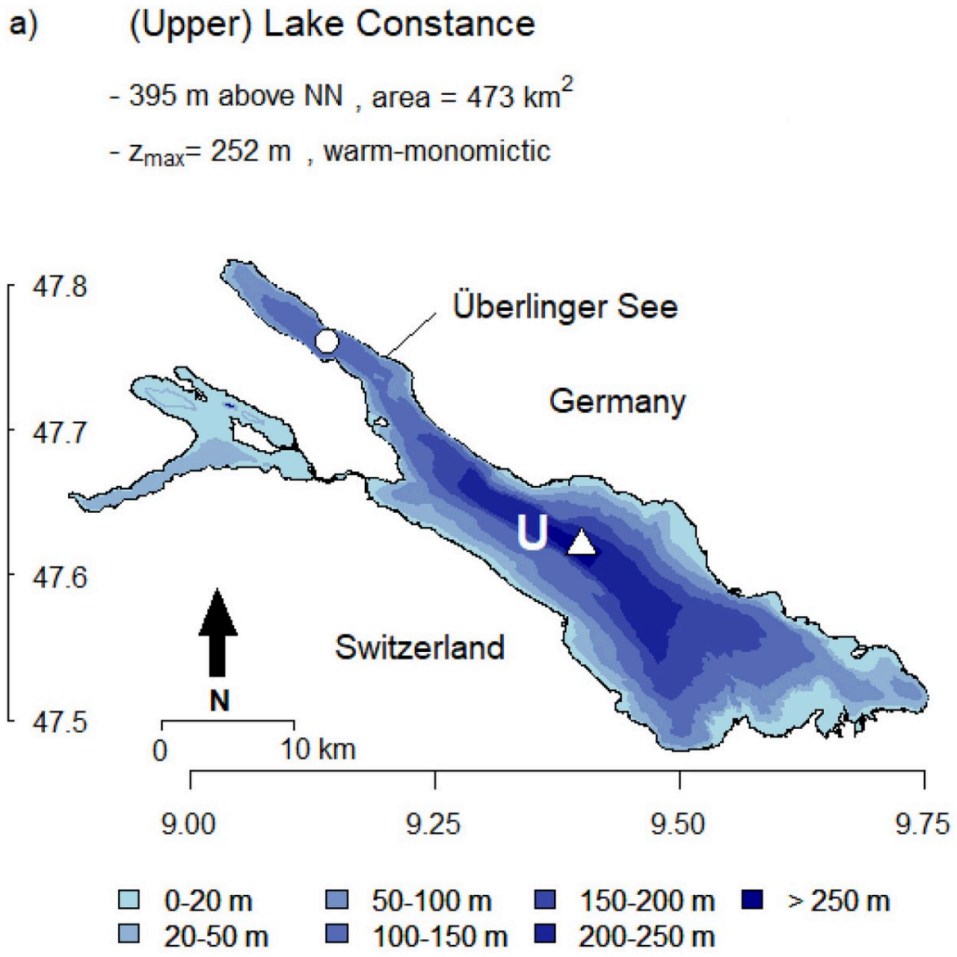
Plankton regime shifts can be detected and partly explained by biotic drivers. Whether they propagate and can be predicted is still open.

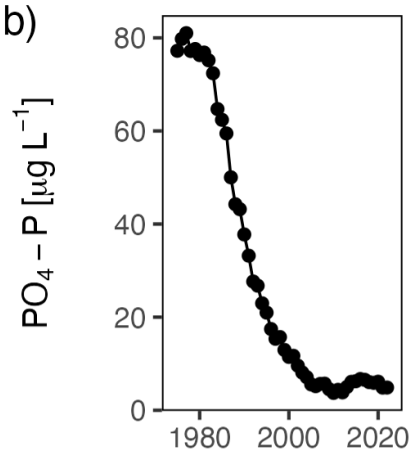


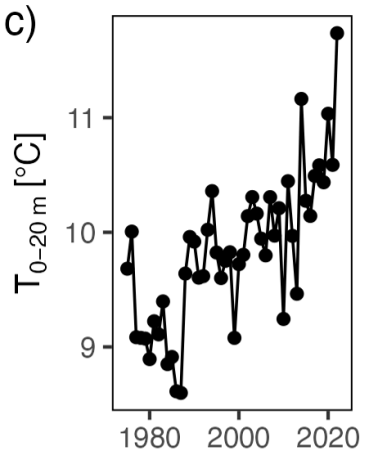
Outline

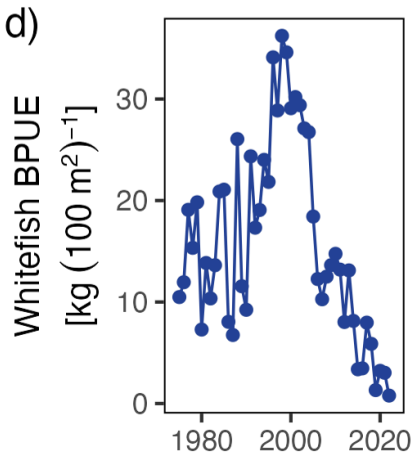
1. What we know: background
2. Research questions
3. Methods: our pipeline
4. Results: detection of regime shifts
5. Explain regime shifts
6. Propagation of regime shifts
7. Conclusions

What we know: background







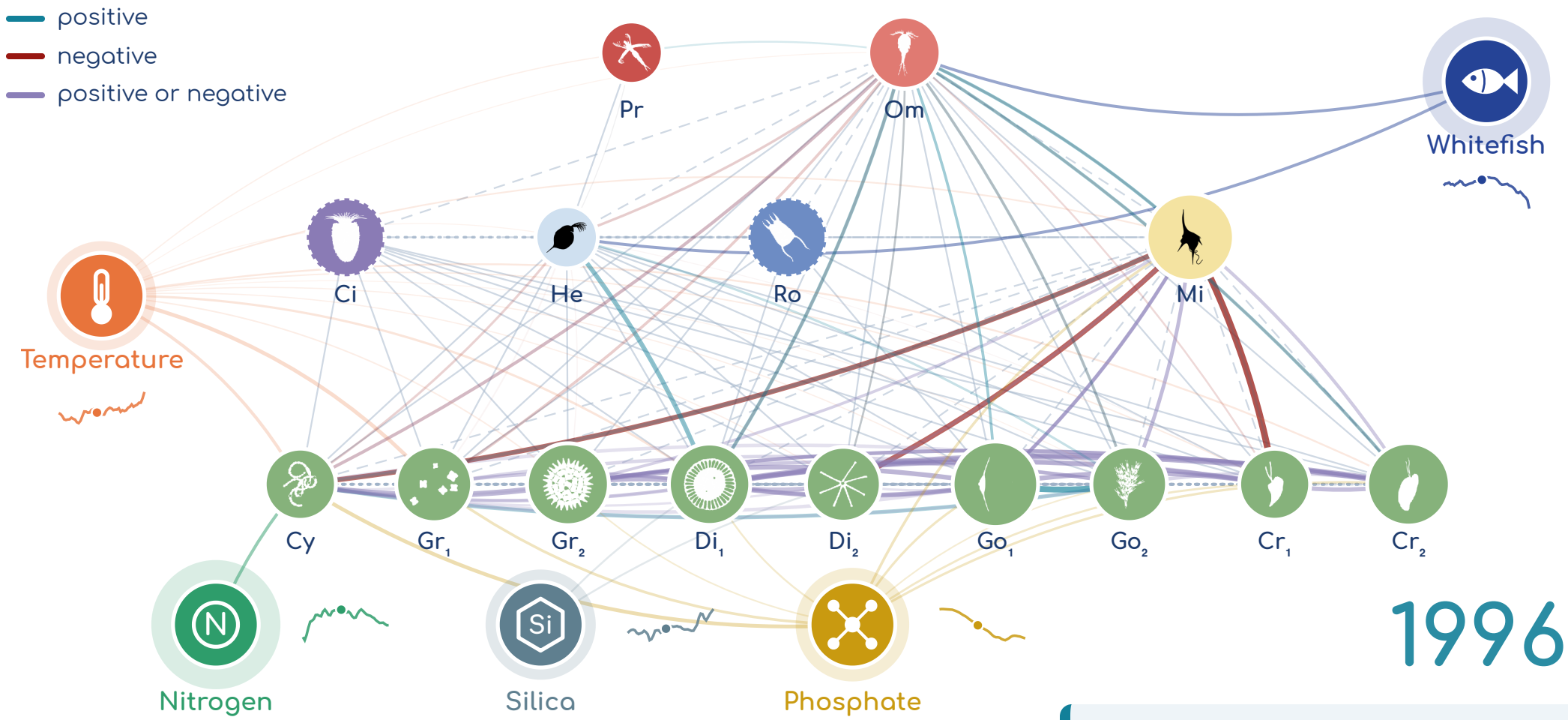


Lake Constance
473 km² · 252 m deep

Phosphate ↑ until 1980, then ↓

Temperature ↑ about 1 °C

What we know: the plankton community



Study period: **1975–2022** · monthly time series

The plankton community changes across time

Network modified from Merz et al. 2023, Nat. Clim. Change.

Research questions



1 · Detect

Abrupt shifts?



2 · Explain

What drives them?



3 · Propagate

Does a shift spread?



4 · Predict

Can we forecast them? (in progress)

Methods: our pipeline

1

Data

Monthly data 1975–2022

2

Detect

BEAST + two criteria

3

Explain

GP-EDM + hypotheses

4

Propagate

Shift-removal test

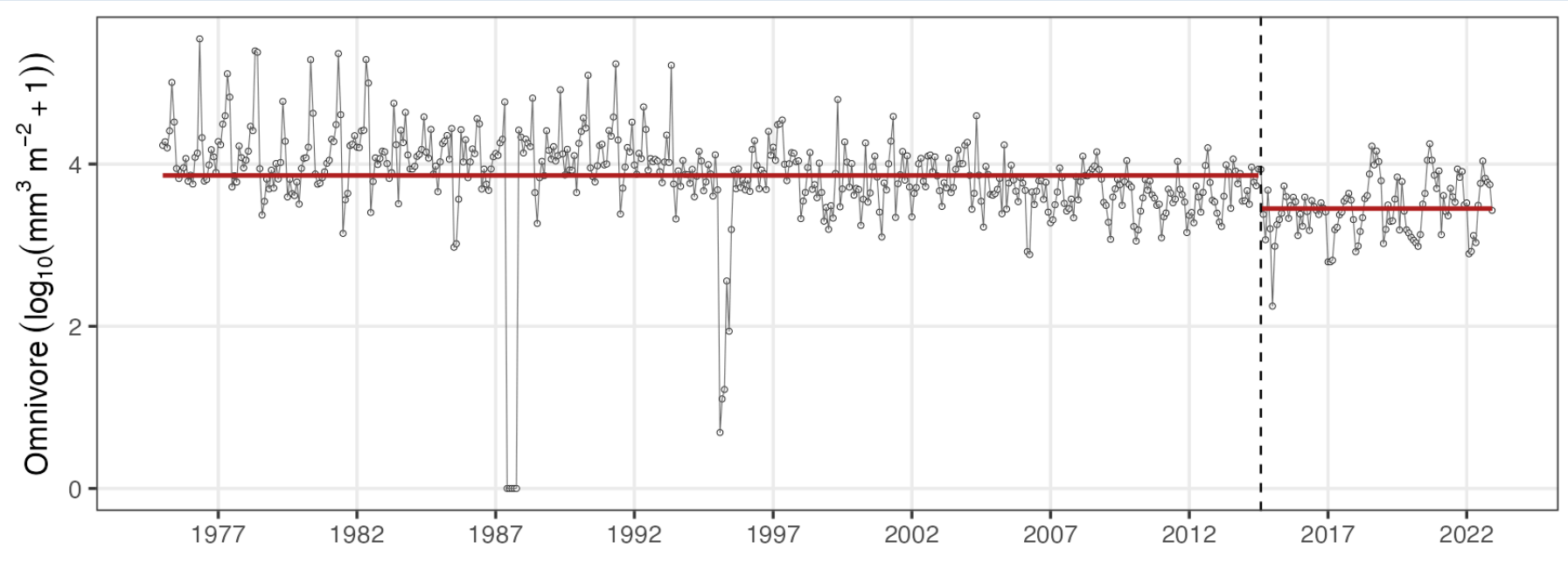
5

Predict

Forward validation

WORK IN PROGRESS

Results: detection of regime shifts



Omnivores, monthly biovolume. Dashed: shift; red: period means.

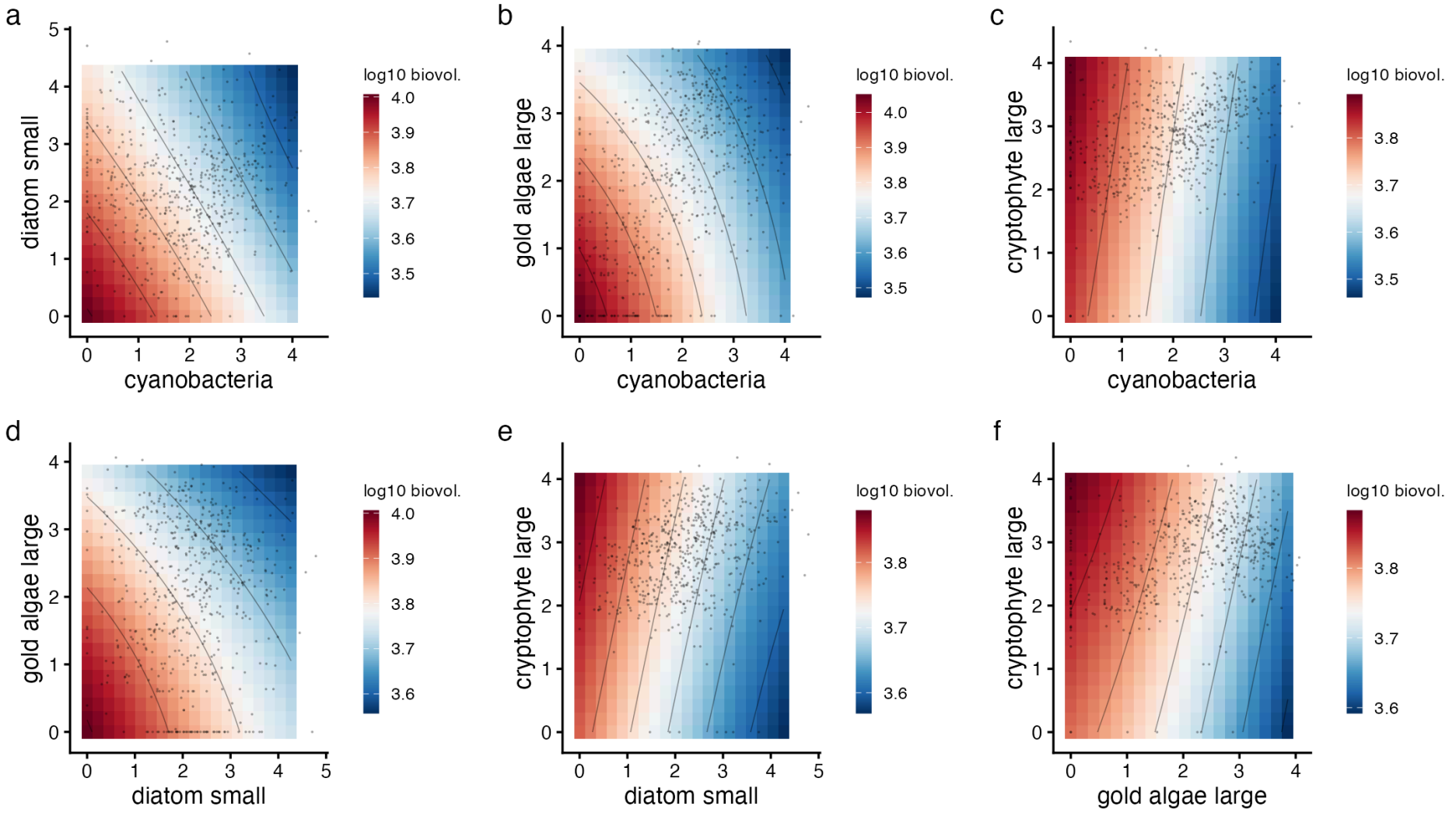


Shift: Aug 2014

abruptness 1.19

The omnivores dropped abruptly in 2014

Explain regime shifts



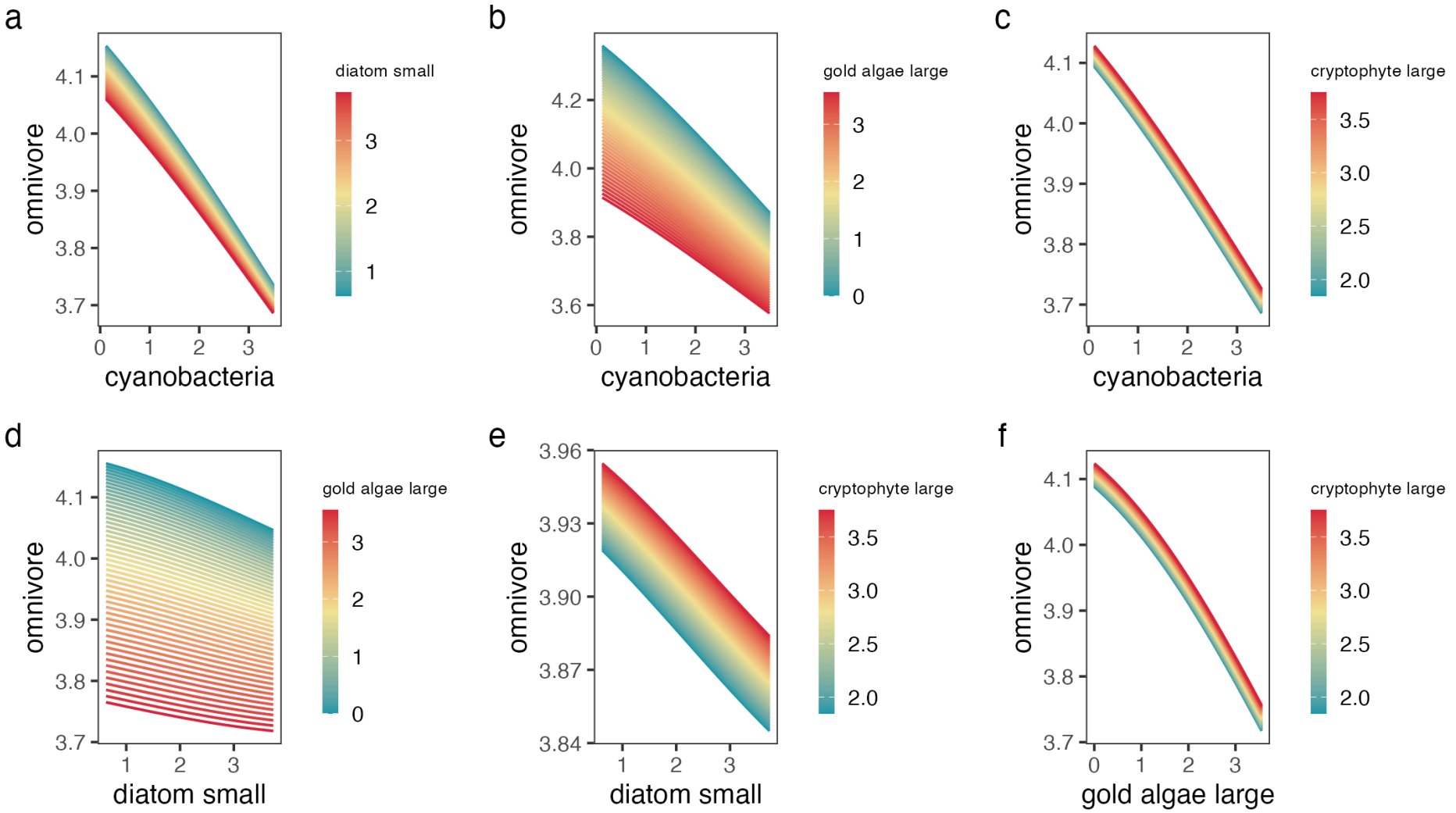


LOO R^2 = **0.81**

Omnivores ↓ with cyanobacteria, small diatoms, large gold algae

Prey hypothesis: **not supported**

Explain regime shifts: partial dependence





x: predictor 1
lines: predictor 2

Cyanobacteria ↓ omnivores

Lines never cross

Propagation of regime shifts

1 · Real predictor



2 candidate pairs

0 testable

Predictor shifted **after**

2 · Shift-free surrogate (× 100)



Gap between real and surrogate prediction = evidence for propagation

No evidence yet: too few shifts

Conclusions



Shifts are detectable



Biotic drivers matter



Propagation, prediction: open

Take home message

Plankton regime shifts can be detected and partly explained by biotic drivers. Whether they propagate and can be predicted is still open.



Acknowledgements

Interreg
Alpenrhein-Bodensee-Hochrhein

Kofinanziert von der Europäischen Union

igkb
Internationale Gewässerschutzkommission für den Bodensee

IBKF

Supported by the Biodiversity Center WSL–Eawag

eawag aquatic research

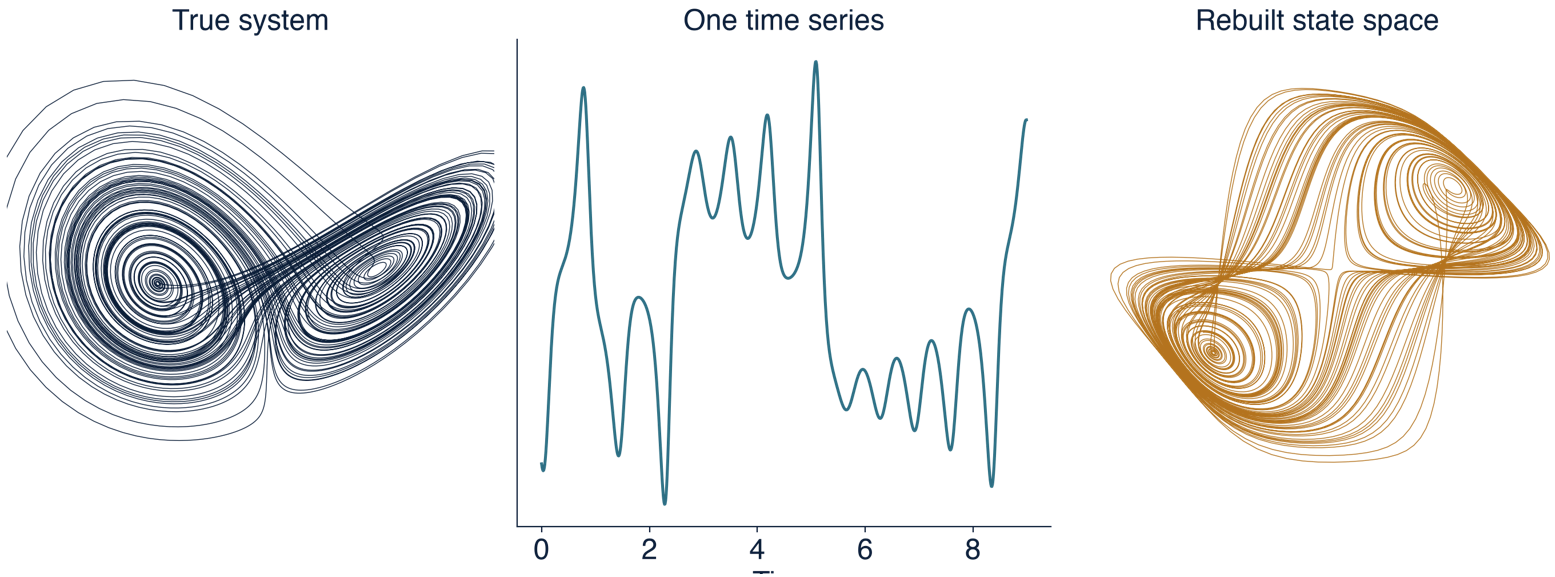
WSL

SeeWandel-Climate · Pomati lab and colleagues at Eawag
Luis J. Gilarranz · Stefanie Eyring · Stephan B. Munch · Tanya L. Rogers · Francesco Pomati
Data: IGKB, IBKF, University of Konstanz (D. Straile)

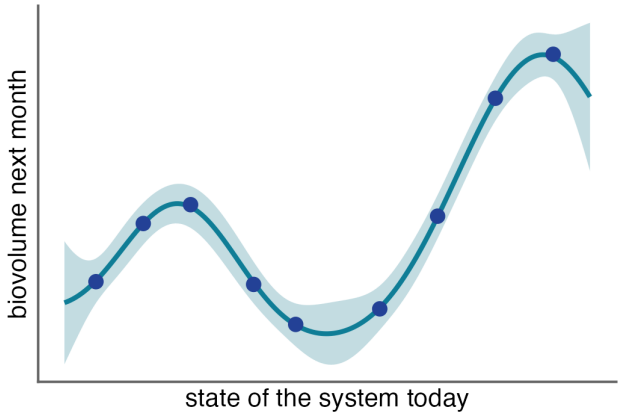
Supplementary materials



What is GP-EDM?



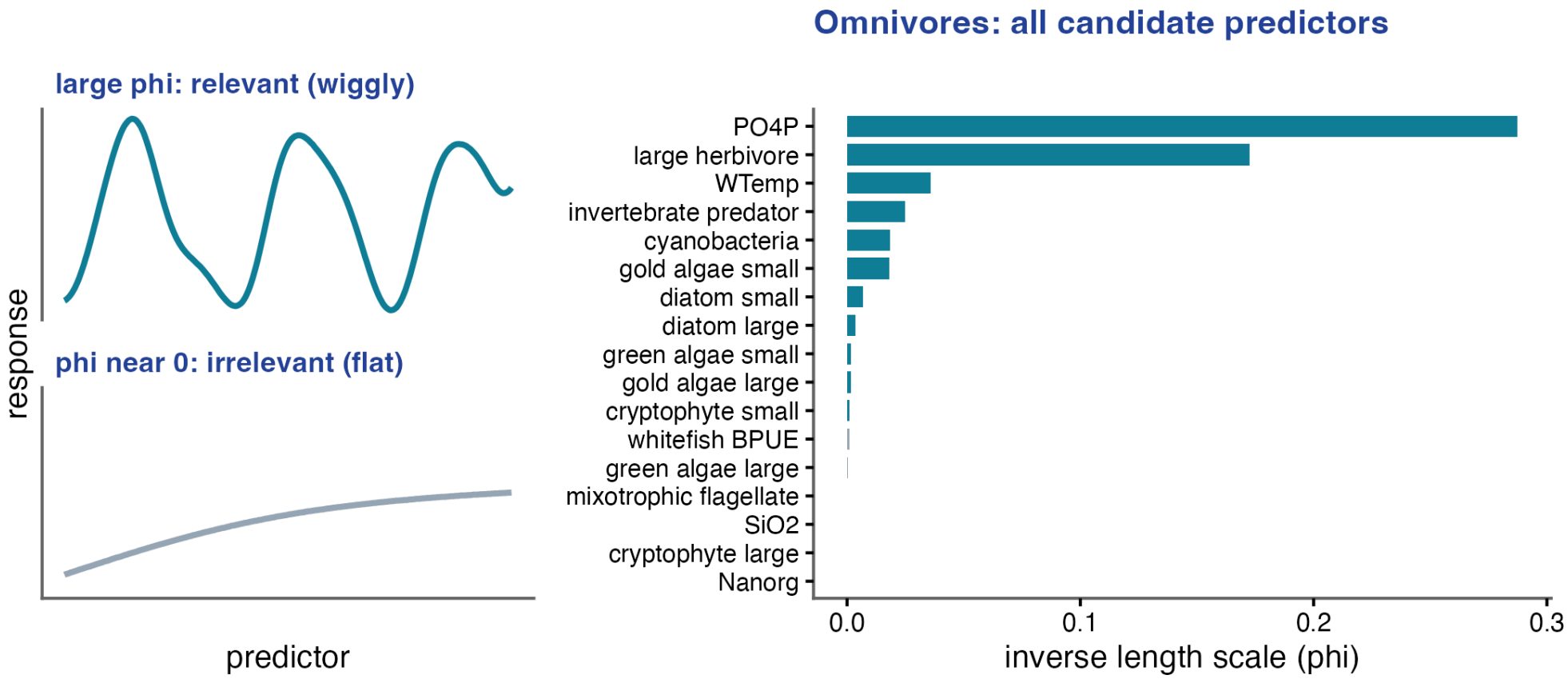
Gaussian process: no fixed equation



Next month = f(past states, drivers)

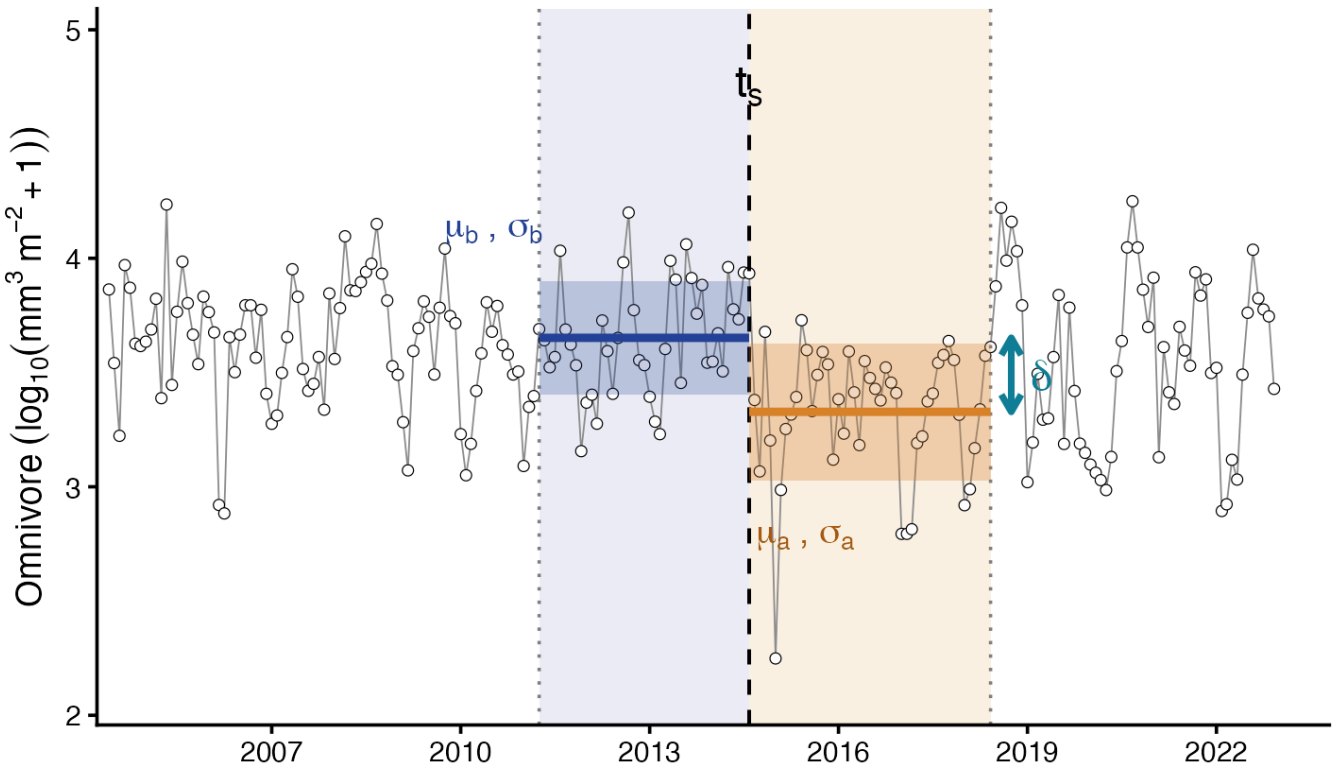
f learned from the data: Gaussian process

Automatic relevance determination (ARD)



One length scale per predictor: **phi near 0** = predictor dropped

Detecting regime shifts: BEAST and two criteria



1 BEAST: candidate shift

t_s : Pr(change point) = 0.87

2 Difference of the two chunks

$\delta = \mu_a - \mu_b \quad 0 \notin CI_{95\%}(\delta)$

CI = [0.19, 0.42] ✓

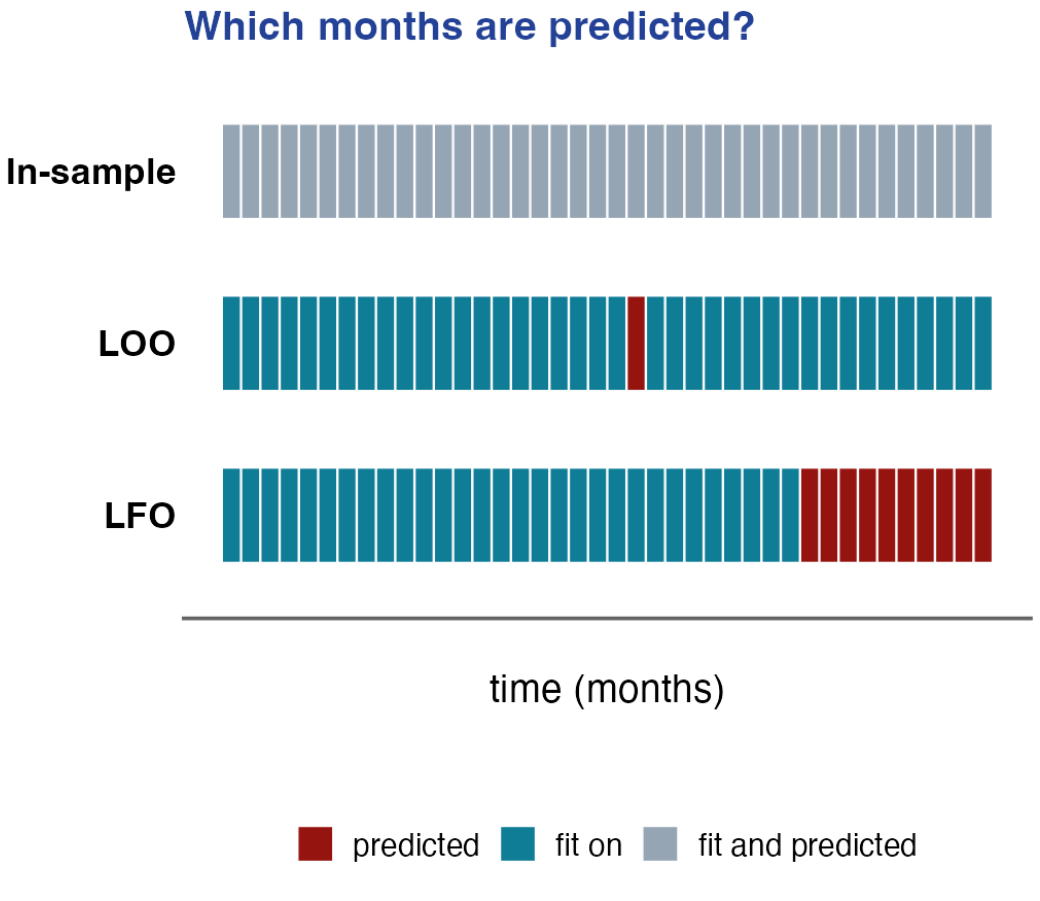
3 Abruptness

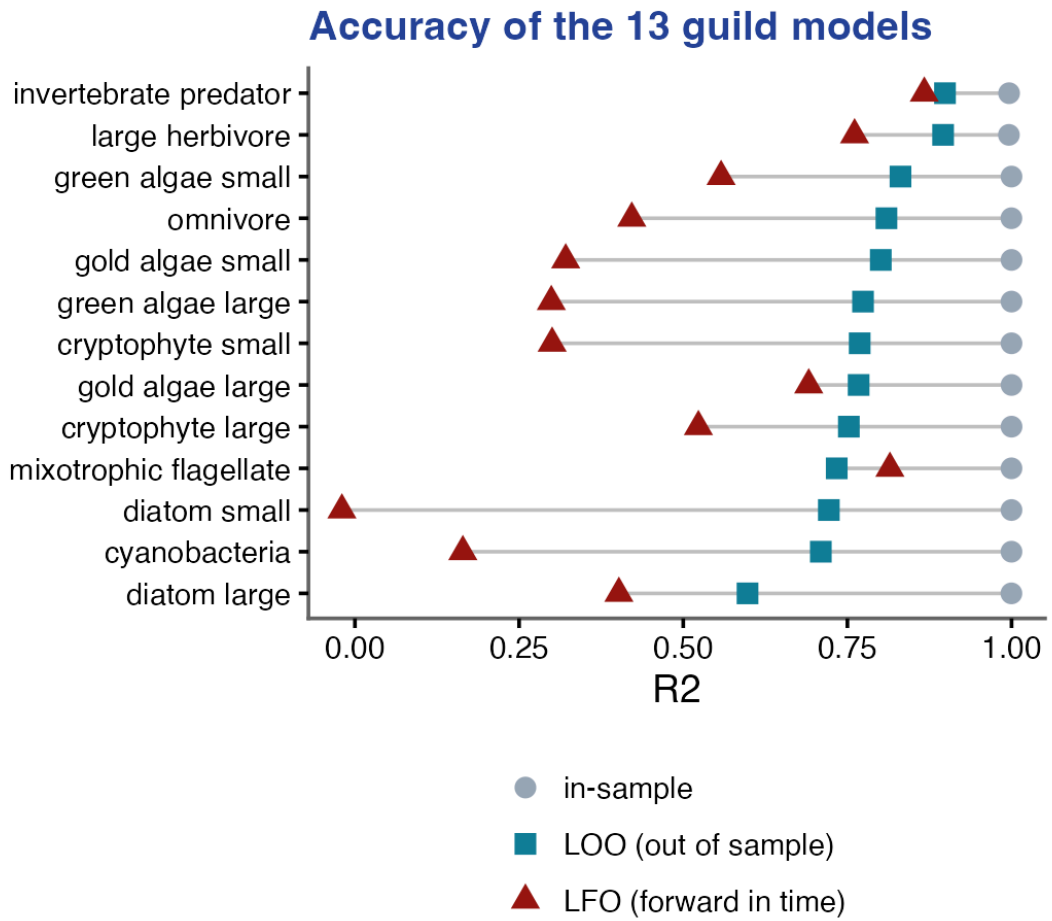
$$a = \frac{|\mu_a - \mu_b|}{\frac{1}{2}(\sigma_b + \sigma_a)} > 1$$

a = 1.19 ✓

Kept if 2 and 3 hold

In-sample versus out-of-sample R^2





In-sample: $R^2 = 1$, a GP interpolates

LOO: one month left out

LFO: forecast the last 10 %

Which genera? Zooplankton and mixotrophs



Invertebrate predators

Pr

Leptodora	73%
Bythotrephes	27%



Omnivores

Om

Cyclops	80%
Mesocyclops	17%
Acanthocyclops	1%
Thermocyclops	1%
Asplanchna	0%

+ 4 more



Large herbivores

He

Daphnia	91%
Eudiaptomus	6%
Bosmina	2%
Diaphanosoma	1%
Acanthodiaptomus	0%

+ 6 more



Mixotrophic flagellates

Mi

Ceratium	46%
Gymnodinium	45%
Peridinium	7%
other Flagellaten	1%
other Phytoflagellaten	0%

+ 14 more

Top genera by share of biovolume, IGKB 1975–2022

Which genera? Phytoplankton (1/2)



Cyanobacteria

Cy colonial

Anabaena	44%
Aphanizomenon	16%
Planktothrix	9%
Cyanothece	7%
Aphanothece	6%

+ 25 more



Green algae, small

Gr1 ≤ 550 µm³

Volvocales	30%
unidentified algae	24%
Chlorella	21%
Oocystis	7%
Characium	3%

+ 21 more

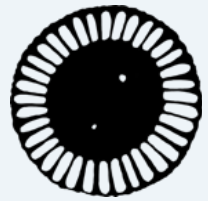


Green algae, large

Gr2 > 550 µm³ or colonial

other Chlorococcales	23%
Pandorina	18%
Mougeotia	16%
Chlamydomonas	10%
Ulothrix	6%

+ 46 more

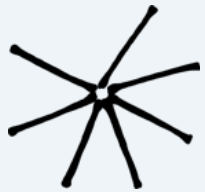


Diatoms, small

Di1 ≤ 800 µm³

Stephanodiscus	81%
Cyclotella	17%
Achnanthes	1%
Fragilaria	1%
Nitzschia	0%

+ 9 more



Diatoms, large

Di2 > 800 µm³ or colonial

Fragilaria	50%
Stephanodiscus	15%
Asterionella	14%
Cyclotella	10%
Tabellaria	4%

+ 18 more

Top genera by share of biovolume, IGKB 1975–2022

Which genera? Phytoplankton (2/2)



Gold algae, small

Go1 ≤ 250 µm³

Erkenia	63%
Chrysochromulina	23%
Chromulina	4%
Ochromonas	2%
Pseudokephyrion	2%

+ 13 more



Gold algae, large

Go2 > 250 µm³ or colonial

Dinobryon	42%
Mallomonas	17%
Uroglena	12%
Chrysophyceae	12%
Pseudopedinella	6%

+ 9 more



Cryptophytes, small

Cr1 ≤ 700 µm³

Rhodomonas	99%
Plagioselmis	1%
Cyathomonas	0%
Cryptaulax	0%
Chilomonas	0%

+ 1 more



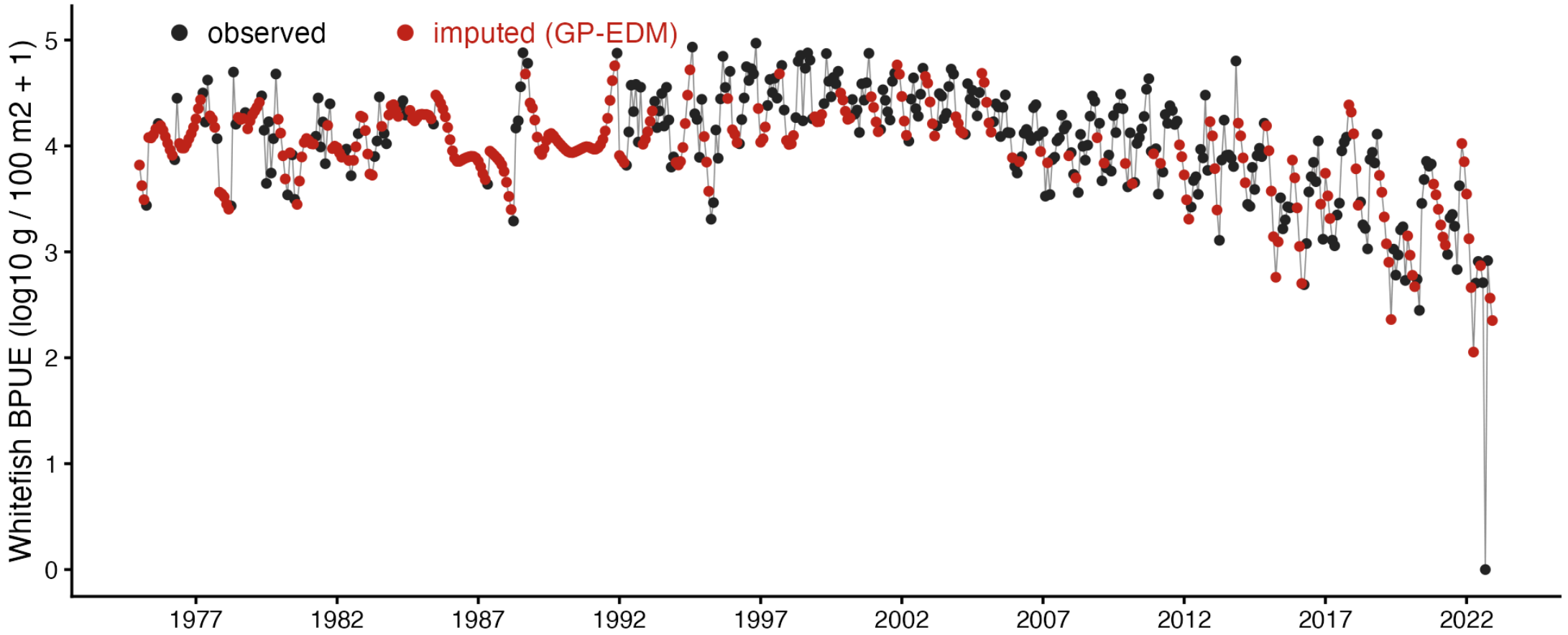
Cryptophytes, large

Cr2 > 700 µm³

Cryptomonas	100%
other Cryptophyceen	0%

Top genera by share of biovolume, IGKB 1975–2022

Whitefish time series: observed and imputed



287 of 576 months imputed (50 %)

GP-EDM, LOO R^2 = 0.55

References

Eyring S, Merz E, Reyes M, Ntetsika P, et al. 2025. Distinct phytoplankton size classes respond differently to biotic and abiotic factors. ISME Communications 5: ycae148.

Gilarranz LJ, Narwani A, Odermatt D, Siber R, Dakos V. 2022. Regime shifts, trends, and variability of lake productivity at a global scale. PNAS 119: e2116413119.

Medeiros LP, Sorenson DK, Johnson BJ, Palkovacs E, Munch SB. 2025. Revealing unseen dynamical regimes of ecosystems from population time-series data. PNAS 122: e2416637122.

Merz E, Saberski E, Gilarranz LJ, Isles PDF, et al. 2023. Disruption of ecological networks in lakes by climate change and nutrient fluctuations. Nature Climate Change 13: 389–396.

Munch SB, Poynor V, Arriaza JL. 2017. Circumventing structural uncertainty: a Bayesian perspective on nonlinear forecasting for ecology. Ecological Complexity 32: 134–143.

Ntetsika P, Eyring S, Merz E, Reyes M, et al. 2026. Biotic interactions shape the realized niche of toxic cyanobacteria. Nature Ecology & Evolution 10: 1434–1448.

Takens F. 1981. Detecting strange attractors in turbulence. Lecture Notes in Mathematics 898: 366–381.

To S-W, Chakraborty S, Acevedo-Trejos E, Pomati F, et al. 2026. Future warming reshapes inorganic nutrient and plankton dynamics in a temperate lake. Limnology and Oceanography 71: e70447.

Lake Constance map (panel a): adapted from the published figure provided by the author. Panels b–d: IGKB monitoring data (phosphate, temperature) and IBKF whitefish catches, annual means 1975–2022.